NOVELISTIC SCREENPLAY

POKÉMON NOCTURNE

EPISODE 07

White and Snowy Hell

Author

Adelbert Vervloet

Working compilation

Status · draft · pass 1/3 recorded · EN-GB apparatus

Format	Novelistic screenplay · EN anchors
Target duration	To be set — corpus ≈ 75 min read aloud
Scenes	11
Version	2026-09-23 · EN-GB dossier after P1

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Episode sheet

Series Pokémon Nocturne

Episode 07 — White and Snowy Hell

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Logline

The snow is not the end: it is the return. Pryce names the ancient breath. Lambda fires them with Explosion. Eusine lends Haunter. Athena wears them down. Lance (Team Rocket) lets them through. At the summit, Apollo offers a job interview.

Place in the arc

Due: Murkrow's cry; bark off-screen; message to Giovanni.

Paid: Icy Wind; Weezing / Explosion; Silver intercepted; Houndoom named; Dex read by Apollo.

Open: battle at the summit; Eusine vs Lance (Team Rocket); Guardian of Hell.

Characters — this episode only

Name	Function here
Gold/Richter · Chris/Maria	Crop; Dewgong / Icy Wind
Pryce	Nameless ghost; TM Icy Wind
Eusine / Morty	Strategic split; prayer without relief
Lambda	Rhetorical terrorism; false Giovanni
Athena	Haze; Pursuit; attrition — single EN spelling
Lance (Team Rocket)	Passage left open; timing
Apollo	Candidacy; imprecation

Places (EN anchors)

Goldenrod · Pryce's house · station · Bell Tower (Ecruteak) · Radio Tower.

Technical notes — outside the scenes

Heading	Note
Icy Wind	GSC TM, not HGSS. Given by Pryce. Use with restraint.
niveleur	Single spelling. Explosion ≠ Self-Destruct: TM, the director's exception.

Lambda (HGSS)	5 Koffing Lv. 30+ · 1 Weezing. Here Weezing 34. One Koffing already defused before Weezing. Not Lamba.
Pursuit	Power raised 40 → 80: risk of being read on recall / on those who flee. Doubled against flight. Never “the chase”.
Cry	Looong live Master Giovanni! — not Long live, not Viiiive in the EN body.
Crops / balls	hunting crop only. Poké Balls — never bullets.
Two Lances	Here: Rocket executive ランス. Champion ワタル is the other.

BGM index — pieces (OST)

Scene	Piece	Span
Wisdom of ice	Making Monsters	entry · 00:48–end
Rhetorical terrorism	Reborn	entry
Rhetorical terrorism	Always	01:47–end
Rhetorical terrorism	Vive la révolution	00:30– · 01:38–02:00
Suicune hunter?	Vampire Messiah	entry
Weight of promises	Lamento della Ninfa	entry
The heroes’ vulnerabilities	Alone for Many Years	entry
Trial / Athena	Your Choice	~01:42 · 02:38 · 03:26 · the rest
Interview	Work of the Devil	entry

BGM index — traces

Address only.

Scene	BGM
Return of oppression	EP07 S01 11:24–12:46
The heroes’ vulnerabilities	Lacrimosa — Mozart, Édouard’s version in Nocturne
Prayer without relief	EP03 S02 16:50–17:30
Job interview	EP01 S02 22 :51-23 :40

Order of scenes

1. The Return of Lapsed Oppression
2. The Wisdom of Ice
3. A Prayer without Relief
4. Rhetorical Terrorism
5. Are You Really Just a Suicune Hunter?
6. The Weight of Promises
7. The Flame in the Snow
8. The Heroes' Vulnerabilities
9. Clinical Trial of the God of Death
10. Radio Tower (stealth passage)
11. A Job Interview

The scenes are inserted here. The close follows the body.

Scene – The Return of Lapsed Oppression

Night in Goldenrod City

BGM 'EP07 S01 11:24–12:46'

Snow fell silently over Goldenrod.

Two figures were still making their way along, too close to one another to be mere passers-by. They spoke in hushed tones. Between them lingered a worn delight — the remnants of an evening, a word too intimate, a laugh that hadn't quite died away. The city around them had already withdrawn.

Then the Murkrow appeared.

It didn't plummet from the sky. It was perched in the middle of the road, slightly askew, as if it were occupying the road merely for convenience. Its gaze accused no one. A neutrality too clear, almost specious, and beneath that clarity something mischievous that didn't need to show itself.

Their conversation came to a halt.

It wasn't acute fear. It was older, more anonymous: a nameless, inherited aversion, directed less against that particular bird than against their generation. They didn't know where that tightness in their chests came from. They merely recognised it.

The Murkrow lingered a second too long — long enough for them to realise it had nothing to prove. Then it took flight. Nonchalantly. Without honouring them with a threat. Its wings barely stirred the snow.

In front of a shop with its shutters closed, a woman came to a halt. Another Murkrow hovered below the rooftops, circling slowly. She did not go inside straight away. She stood with her back slightly hunched, her shoulders tense, as if her body remembered before her mind did what this used to mean, back when such presences became too numerous. It was only once the shadow had moved on that she went inside, without looking back.

Further on, two men fell silent in front of a closed door. They did not look up. One instinctively pulled his coat collar tighter against a cold that was no longer just that of the snow. They then resumed their conversation, speaking even more quietly than before.

On the steps of a modest house, an old woman was still holding her broom. When a Murkrow flew right overhead, she stopped dead in her tracks. Her gaze fixed on the ground. Her fingers clenched around the wood. It was not terror. It was a weary recognition: she had seen these birds return before. This time, they seemed less inclined to fly away.

No one was shouting. No one was running.

The town did not seem to fear death. It seemed to fear **the return**.

The Murkrow did not herald the end. They served as a reminder that something ancient, rigid and relentless continued to circle above the rooftops — and that, this time, it was not certain that it could be driven back again.

End of scene

Scene – The Wisdom of Ice

Interior – Pryce's house

BGM 'Making Monsters'

The room was dimly lit by the fire crackling in the hearth. Pryce remained seated in his armchair, his hands clasped. Gold/Richter stood, looking weary. The discussion seemed to be well underway.

Pryce spoke in a calm, measured voice:

'Team Rocket isn't just a criminal organisation. It's a form of decay that resurfaces when the conditions are right. They no longer need a leader to exist. They've learnt to function even when fragmented. That is precisely what makes them so persistent.'

He paused briefly, then continued:

"In Kanto, as in Johto, there were once tales of an insidious, ancient ghost with no fixed name. Over time, in Johto, we have almost forgotten its name. Tradition, and our legendary ancestors, Ho-Oh and Lugia, have obscured its memory. In Kanto, they still speak of it… but as a story to scare children. Here in Johto, we no longer speak its name… but we can still feel its breath in the wind."

Pryce looked up slightly at Gold/Richter.

"Those crows you faced… their ancestors were already here, many centuries ago, when that spectre still roamed freely through these lands. They are not powerful through brute force. They intercept. They herald. And for some time now, they've been behaving as though that presence has returned. They don't exactly embody death, but a persistent violence, an oppressive memory, an order… a very ancient one."

His voice darkened slightly:

"The most worrying thing is that even without their original leader, their cruelty seems to have grown in intensity. This isn't simply a matter of an organisation having been decapitated. Something else is guiding them."

Silence fell, broken only by the crackling of the fire. Pryce rose slowly, fetched a small, worn metal box from an antique cabinet, then returned to hand it to Gold/Richter:

"Here. This is the TM 'Icy Wind'. It's not a spectacular ability, but it can give you some breathing space when things get too hectic. Use it sparingly."

Background music: 'Making Monsters' – 00:48–end

Pryce remained standing in front of him and added, in a lower voice:

'You are a Pokédex holder. You carry more than mere data. Professor Oak was publicly a great scientist… but he was also one of us. You carry a part of his will.'

He paused briefly, then concluded in a slightly lighter tone, almost with a hint of intergenerational tenderness:

“You’ve already defeated an Ice Master. So a bit of snow—even persistent snow—shouldn’t stop you. Even if it comes from a winter older than we are.”

Gold/Richter took the box without a word. He looked at it for a moment, then put it away carefully. He nodded slightly. His gaze remained weary, but a little less lonely.

End of scene

Scene – A prayer without relief

Goldenrod was still asleep. The station, usually bustling, seemed to have been emptied in an instant. The trains had stopped running. Team Rocket had, it seemed, tampered with something in the signalling system. Nothing permanent, just enough to paralyse the network for a while. The platforms were deserted. A train stood motionless, as if it had been abandoned long ago. It was as though the city itself had withdrawn.

BGM ‘EP03 S02 16:50 17:30’

Eusine stood in the shadow of a canopy, the phone pressed to his ear. He had not seen fit to wear a disguise. Not this morning.

On the other end of the line, Morty’s voice was calm, almost hushed:

‘So, have you made your decision?’

Eusine paused before replying. His voice retained the slightly affected tone he often adopted, but it sounded hollower than usual.

“I don’t think of myself as a hero. I’m simply… standing by. Nothing more.”

A silence followed. Morty did not immediately respond. When he did, his voice was a little deeper.

“I know all about your passion for Johto… but does it really go that far?”

Eusine lowered his gaze slightly towards the empty platform. It took him a moment to reply.

“Oh no,” confirmed Eusine. “I’m stepping in because… if Red’s successors are going to stand up to Team Rocket just as he did… we can’t just leave them to fend for themselves. Faced with that criminal syndicate from Kanto, my advice would be useful to them. At least, I hope so.”

On the other end of the line, Morty remained silent for a moment. It seemed as though he was weighing his words, or hesitating to say too much.

“I’m sorry that my skills can’t be of much help to you… Especially with the restrictions placed on Gym Leaders. I’m not in a strong enough position,” said Morty.

Eusine gave a faint, joyless smile.

“That is precisely why I shall convey your regards and encouragement to them on your behalf.”

Another brief silence fell. Eusine seemed to hesitate before adding anything. Finally, he did so, in a lower voice:

"By the way… I'm indebted to you for always putting up with me. Just like the people of Johto, for that matter."

Morty made no attempt to play it down. He simply replied, more plainly:

"Then… take care."

Eusine said nothing. He simply hung up. The dial-tone lingered in the air for a moment before fading away.

On the other end of the line, in Ecruteak, Morty stood motionless for a moment, the phone still in his hand. He was not far from the base of the Bell Tower. Dawn was breaking slowly, grey and cold. He looked up at the massive silhouette of the tower, the top of which was still shrouded in darkness.

He wasn't really praying. Not in the usual sense of the word. But there was, in his stillness, something that resembled it. A kind of silent, almost weary plea.

'Will we be able to overcome these challenges…? Master Ho-Oh?'

His voice was no louder than a whisper. He gazed at the tower for another moment, but his expression did not really soften. He then looked down at the small statue of Ho-Oh standing not far away. The expression of the legendary Pokémon, frozen in bronze, remained both austere and strangely generous.

Morty remained alone in front of the tower. Dawn was breaking, grey and cold. There was no one else around.

End of scene

Scene – Rhetorical Terrorism

Lambda vs Gold/Richter. The Director's Office at the Radio Tower

Snow was still falling outside, but on the top floor of the Radio Tower the air had grown heavy, almost unbreathable. Another explosive echo, more muffled than the previous ones, rang out in the distance. Gold/Richter recalled his Pokémon with a sharp gesture. He did not need to see the damage to imagine it.

He discreetly consulted the niveleur.

"…It's not 'Self-Destruct'. It's 'Explosion'."

His voice was low.

'A Weezing at this level shouldn't have been able to internalise it. Is it a TM?'

Lambda shrugged slightly. There was neither pride nor excessive shame in his demeanour — just a kind of weary realism. He picked up Weezing's Poké Ball:

“The use of TMs is prohibited under our work code. Too conspicuous, too risky. But the director made an exception. A concession and a reward, so to speak.”

Gold/Richter slowly looked up. “A reward… for what?”

BGM ‘Reborn’

Lambda crossed his arms, gazing absently out of the window where the snow continued to fall.

“Because it works better this way. Giovanni would never have considered such a dirty… and vulgar method. He wanted everything to remain controlled, disciplined. But the new boss… He knows I’m not cut out for acting. And that most of the lads need someone to get them fired up. Even if it’s me. Even if it’s repulsive.”

He tried to pass himself off as Giovanni. It was not a proper disguise, merely a crude imitation of his voice and posture. The result was mediocre, almost pitiful. He did not even seem to believe it himself.

He paused briefly, then added, in a lower voice:

“Me, as Master Giovanni—that’s enough to stir them up. And as long as I give them what they want to hear… they’re more effective. More destructive. That’s all that matters to him.”

Gold/Richter narrowed his eyes slightly.

“And you, do you know that? That you’re nothing but a pawn in this scheme?”

Lambda gave a small, joyless smile, almost resigned.

“Of course I know. I’m not stupid enough to believe I’m indispensable. I rile up the troops; I give them permission to be rowdy and loud. But without the Director’s intelligence, without Athena, without Lance… none of this would last long. I know that very well. I depend on them just as much as they need me. That’s how it works now.”

He abandoned the pretence of a swift gesture and threw a single Poké Ball. A Koffing appeared.

Gold/Richter looked at the three remaining balls on Lambda’s belt:

“…They’re all Koffing. With Self-Destruct.”

Lambda tilted his head slightly, almost amused by his reaction.

“So what? It is effective. If you can resolve the problem more quickly and simply, why bother with complicated methods? As long as it is within the rules…”

Gold/Richter stared at him for a long moment. When he spoke, his voice was low, almost a whisper:

“You turn your sadism into efficiency. Your terrorism into strategy. You hide your contempt for life behind rhetoric of victory… which doesn’t even work against every type.”

Lambda shrugged with a sort of grotesque sincerity. “Hey. I’m just telling it like it is. Lots of trainers think the same way. They’re all looking for the quickest way to win. I’m just more direct. Why waste time and energy when you can finish it all in one go? It makes sense.”

Gold/Richter fell silent for a moment, feeling the tension rise within his chest.

“Bloody hell… My Haunter isn’t meant for battle. I didn’t bring it along… What should I do?” he muttered to himself.

BGM "Always" 01:47–the end

Lambda raised his hand slowly. The Koffing already present swelled slightly. The three remaining Poké Balls on his belt began to tremble. One word, one gesture, and everything would explode.

BGM: 'Vive la révolution' – 00:30–

Then a purple hand darted from the shadows, swift and precise. It struck the Koffing before it could detonate. *Sucker Punch.* The blow abruptly halted the attempted explosion, but the Koffing, violently hurled against the wall, was not yet out of action. It staggered to its feet, its body still swollen with gas.

Gold/Richter turned round, taken aback. A henchman was approaching slowly. White shoes. Far too clean.

The henchman removed his mask as he walked. "I hope I'm not too late."

Gold/Richter blinked. "…Mr Eusine?"

Eusine looked at the three Poké Balls still hanging from Lambda's belt, then turned to Gold/Richter. "I'm here on Morty's behalf… or rather, at his kind request. He can't come in person because of his Gym Leader restrictions, but he was worried about you. ' He gestured discreetly towards his Haunter. 'And since you seem to be short of a Ghost-type ally…'

He looked calmly at Gold/Richter. "You have two choices. Either I take over, or you carry on with my Haunter. It's up to you."

Gold/Richter hesitated for a second, then recalled his Seadra.

"…The second option."

Eusine nodded. With a fluid motion, he recalled his Haunter into its Poké Ball. The ball flew straight towards Gold/Richter.

"Over to you!"

Gold/Richter caught the ball in mid-air.

"To vitalise a Pokémon's potential ethically isn't part of your duties as a Pokédex holder, is it?" murmured Eusine.

Gold/Richter did not reply; he did not need to. He already knew this Haunter's strengths. Without a word, he released the Pokémon.

BGM: 'Vive la révolution' – 01:38–02:00

The Haunter vanished almost instantly. When it reappeared, its *Sucker Punch* was more powerful, more direct. The Koffing, already weakened, was this time knocked out without a fight.

Gold/Richter drew his hunting crop with a sharp movement. For a brief moment, an almost imperceptible blue glow seemed to run along the leather. With a precise and violent gesture, he the three remaining Poké Balls hanging from Lambda's belt. The bullets were flung far away, out of reach, before Lambda could give the order.

Silence fell, broken only by Gold/Richter's heavy breathing. He was weary. Deeply weary.

Lambda, still reeling, managed to say: '…That's cheating. Two against one.'

Eusine regarded him calmly.

“No. I thwarted an attempted terrorist attack, not a battle. And I’m not quite a League Trainer. I’m a Suicune hunter. Sometimes, that allows me to bend certain rules.” He made a discreet gesture towards his Haunter. “Good night.”

The Haunter appeared behind Lambda. *Hypnosis.* Lambda collapsed without a sound.

Gold/Richter stood motionless for a moment, the hunting crop still in his hand. Outside, the snow continued to fall, indifferent.

End of scene

Scene – Are you really just a Suicune hunter?

BGM ‘Vampire Messiah’

Near a small, disused building, out of the way of the Murkrow patrols. Snow was falling in the grey twilight. Inside, the room was cold and dimly lit.

Eusine placed a magnetic card and several Poké Balls of Lambda on the table. He mechanically wiped his gloved hands.

‘Sorry I’m late. I took a detour to free the hostages. Here’s the access card… The radio tower manager handed it to me before I let him out.’

Gold/Richter examined the items for a moment, then looked up.

“Did you see anything else?”

Eusine nodded, his expression serious.

“Their security was unusually lax. I was able to get in without much difficulty. And they’ve sabotaged several trains on the Kanto-Johto line. Enough to delay any potential reinforcements. It’s… methodical. Almost too much so.”

Chris/Maria crossed her arms, looking tense.

“Do you think they’re planning something bigger?”

Eusine paused for a moment, then replied in a lower voice:

“Their plan is ambitious and very fragile. Everything seems to hinge on the return of their former leader. If Giovanni comes back and regains control… Johto will probably stand no chance. Even Lance might not be enough.”

Gold/Richter frowned slightly.

“Do you think Champion Lance will not be able to contain him?”

“Lance is still part of the system. Giovanni, on the other hand, has been out of it for a long time. He no longer has the strength of a Gym Leader. And if they join forces, along with the other executives… we’ll be overwhelmed before we’ve even had a chance to react.”

Chris/Maria clenched her fists.

“Then we cannot wait.”

Eusine looked at her calmly.

“A hasty attack would only turn you into martyrs. Just like that red-haired boy.”

Gold/Richter sat up slightly.

“...Was Silver there?”

“He was obsessed with the idea of facing their leader. He was intercepted by two executives – Lance and Athena.”

Chris/Maria *let slip*:

“Were they really that strong?”

“It’s not a question of raw power,” replied Eusine. “Their Pokémon don’t look particularly special… but they’re well-trained. They don’t charge in blindly. They observe, they wait, and they strike with precision. They’re professionals. Underestimating this sort of opponent is a mistake you only make once.”

“But that explains why I have encountered fewer henchmen. They were dealing with Silver…” he blurted out. “...How did Silver lose?”

“He had the numerical advantage against Athena… until Lance attacked him from behind. A well-planned ambush.”

A heavy silence fell. Gold/Richter lowered his head slightly, his expression darkening. Eusine spoke up:

“Incidentally, Team Rocket’s last guardian is a Pokémon called Houndoom. Its alias is the Guardian of Hell.”

“Houndoom? What type is that Pokémon?” he asked.

“it is reasonable that it should be new to you. This Pokémon isn’t from Johto. During my infiltration, I didn’t come across any Houndoom. Which means its trainer—the current director—probably keeps it close by. We could sometimes hear its barking in the city… deeper, more macabre than the cawing of the Murkrow. It is not so much its presence that is unsettling. It is the fact that we can hear it without seeing it. You get used to seeing Murkrow. But that cry… it sticks in your head. It gnaws at your mind.”

Gold/Richter asked:

“Are you from Kanto?”

Eusine gave a wry smile.

“Celadon. Ironically, I’m originally from the neighbourhood of the gods of death… and the guardian of hell.”

Gold/Richter stared at him for a moment, then nodded slowly.

“...So you’ve seen that hell up close before, then.”

“This isn’t the time for sentimentality.”

Chris/Maria interjected:

“By the way, did the current director ever turn up?”

“Unfortunately, no.”

“Do you have any idea who this Gold/Richter chap is?” she asked.

Gold/Richter replied after a moment’s thought: “…Apollo.”

Eusine raised an eyebrow, clearly surprised.

“Are you sure about that?”

“Lance mentioned that name to me. If the other executive in white is called Athena, then Apollo must be the current director — he’s also dressed in white.”

Chris/Maria observed Gold/Richter, then crossed her arms. Her voice was dry, almost sarcastic:

“Well done. You’ve found his name. Now we know who we’re up against… but we still know nothing about what he’s actually capable of. Don’t start thinking you’re ready just because you’ve put a name to his face.”

Eusine crossed his arms and drew in a short breath, casting a discreet glance at Chris/Maria.

“True. A name does not make the threat any less serious. Sometimes it makes it more tangible.”

A heavier silence settled over the room. Gold/Richter did not reply straight away.

Eusine continued, pragmatically:

“Here is how I suggest we proceed. You will take care of the director. I will deal with Lance. And Chris/Maria will handle Athena.”

Gold/Richter frowned.

“Why this arrangement?”

“Because if Chris/Maria faces Lance and loses, he and Athena will be able to join forces. And if they join the director … we won’t be able to hold them back. By dealing with Lance, I’m preventing that rapid alliance. It’s not a question of brute force. It’s a question of not giving them easy reinforcements,” explained Eusine.

Gold/Richter fell silent for a moment, his expression sombre.

“… Are you really just a Suicune hunter?”

Eusine gave him a faint, weary but clear-eyed smile.

“Hunting Suicune has taught me at least one thing: sometimes, discretion and careful calculation are better than power you do not have.”

Gold/Richter turned to Chris/Maria.

“Do you agree?”

Chris/Maria nodded, without showing much enthusiasm:

“I’ve still got a few Pokémon that can hold out. I’ll take care of it.”

A heavy silence fell. Gold/Richter seemed to bear the weight of the situation.

"...Sorry. I need to talk to you. Alone."

Chris/Maria regarded him, then nodded slightly.

"Very well. You have much to get off your chest."

Eusine nodded with his eyes: "And I'll go about my business."

The two of them left the room. Eusine remained alone for a moment, his eyes fixed on the access card. He exhaled slowly.

"…Youth is sometimes enviable."

End of scene

Scene – The Weight of Promises

Street, in Goldenrod City

BGM: 'Lamento della Ninfa'

Twilight was falling around the tower. Snow was falling in fine, silent flakes, muffling the sounds. They had moved just far enough away to be out of reach of the Murkrow still patrolling the darkening sky. The air was biting. Gold/Richter stood with his arms crossed, his gaze lost in the thickening white.

Chris/Maria stared at him for a moment, her arms also crossed, but with a straighter, more alert posture.

'What are you up to now? As usual, you've got some objections and you want me to come along with you, is that it?'

Gold/Richter shook his head slowly. His voice was low, almost a whisper.

"No. Not this time." He paused. "…I'm grateful to you for agreeing to come, all the same."

Chris/Maria raised an eyebrow, surprised.

"Eh? Are you ill? Hello, is that really you?"

He did not smile. He looked down at the snow piling up on his leather shoes.

"I didn't defeat the Gym Leaders simply because I was a higher level. Without your help… I probably wouldn't have managed it on my own."

A moment of silence followed. Chris/Maria narrowed her eyes slightly.

"Are you expecting a disaster?"

"No." His reply was too quick. He corrected himself, more softly: "I'll do my best. But… I'm afraid I'll owe you an explanation forever if I don't make it back. I'm not as strong as Red. I don't even pretend to be a hero."

Chris/Maria stared at him for a long moment. The edge had gone slightly out of her voice.

“Or are you actually afraid of being one?”

Gold/Richter did not reply straight away. His expression grew heavy, as if something older and heavier had just settled on his shoulders. He turned his head slightly, avoiding her gaze.

Chris/Maria sighed, but without any aggression.

“Go on. Feel free.”

Gold/Richter remained silent for a moment. The snow was falling more heavily now. The wind was barely audible.

“Say… do you remember our childhood promise? Back when we were still little rascals.”

Chris/Maria shrugged, but her voice was quieter.

‘Becoming a Pokédex holder, is that it? You dreamt of being the strongest, like Red or Green. Even though, deep down, you believed it was the way to bring about justice…’

Gold/Richter nodded slowly. His voice was hoarse.

“I was punished by my own naivety. I believed that justice prevailed through the supremacy of power.” He clenched his jaw slightly. “My gratitude towards Red is sincere. But… I also feel his grief deep within me.”

Chris/Maria said nothing. She waited.

“He paid that price so painfully…” murmured Gold/Richter. “I’m reluctant to surpass him by following his example.”

“…Yeah.” Chris/Maria looked down as well. “The most generous of heroes didn’t even deserve a little peace. What an injustice.”

Gold/Richter closed his eyes for a moment. When he opened them again, his voice was more fragile.

“The most agonising thing was that the person he cared about most was torn away from him. It was… so unfair. And so dreadful. I can’t bear to even imagine it.”

Chris/Maria looked at him intently.

“What scared you so much?”

“That loneliness.” He swallowed with difficulty. “I was afraid it would happen again. With someone else. With… you.”

Chris/Maria stood motionless. The snow continued to fall between them.

“Did you try to spare me that…?” she asked softly.

Gold/Richter didn’t reply straight away. He looked down at the snow piling up on his shoes. When he finally spoke, his voice was low and slightly hoarse:

“I couldn’t bear the thought of someone I care deeply about having to endure such loneliness.”

He paused for a longer moment. This time, he seemed to be struggling to continue. When he spoke again, it was almost a whisper:

‘…And I didn’t want to damage the relationship between Misty and Red. I was afraid of exploiting my relationship with you to make myself feel better than him.’

Chris/Maria looked away towards the snow. She didn’t reply straight away. The silence stretched out, heavier than the previous ones.

Gold/Richter clenched his fists in his pockets. He was still staring at the ground when he spoke again, in a more subdued, almost weary voice:

“The most macabre thing… is that we live in an age where we have to acknowledge that love alone, affection alone, is not enough to shield us from evil—not even the most lucid love.”

Chris/Maria remained perfectly still. That sentence seemed to hurt her more than anything he had said so far. She lowered her head slightly, her arms clasped tightly against her, as if trying to protect herself from the cold — or from what he had just said. She did not look at him.

Gold/Richter continued, without looking up:

“If bliss is not granted according to justice… I had to find another way out. Neither Red’s nor Green’s. I wanted to break this curse that seems to afflict Pokédex holders. At least so that it wouldn’t extend to you.”

Chris/Maria turned back to him. Her tone was more weary, but still frank.

“And what was the result?”

Gold/Richter lowered his head. His voice was barely audible.

“All I managed to do was hurt the people who matter most to me. I’ve messed everything up.”

Chris/Maria regarded him for a long time. Then she said, more gently:

“Is that what you’ve been avoiding telling me?”

He nodded faintly.

“…I couldn’t even stop you from accepting the Pokédex. I don’t even know anymore if I wanted to protect you… or protect myself. I’m lost. I don’t expect you to forgive me.”

Chris/Maria fell silent for a moment. The snow was falling harder now. She finally replied, with a bitter half-smile:

“Ah. You underestimated my persistence.”

She crossed her arms, pulling them tighter around herself.

“At first, I accepted the Pokédex partly out of resentment towards you. And to see what sort of person you’d become. I felt responsible for setting you straight, if you went off the rails.” She paused. “But it is a relief to see you have not changed completely. At least… not deep down. As religious and pious as ever for someone of your age.”

Gold/Richter kept his eyes downcast. His face was tense.

Chris/Maria continued, in a lower voice:

“At first, I adopted that sarcasm to take it out on you… and to protect myself. But I couldn’t do without it any longer, since our history has become irreversible. In a way, I have no choice but to resign myself to it and carry on like this.”

Gold/Richter raised his head slightly. His voice was hoarse.

“Thank you for often being by my side. But… don’t push yourself too hard.”

Chris/Maria looked at him for a long time. The weariness in her voice was genuine, but there was something else beneath it.

“…Even so, I’m glad to support you. Even if it’s just out of what remains of our camaraderie. We’ll see later what becomes of us. For now… we still have a little way to go together.”

She turned her head slightly, as if she had caught sight of something in the distance.

“Ah. I almost missed it. Our friends are coming.”

Gold/Richter looked up, a little bewildered.

“…Who?”

End of scene

Scene – The Flame in the Snow

Twilight had deepened. Snow fell silently around the old building, muffling the sounds from outside. They had gathered in small groups, at staggered times, to avoid attracting the Murkrow that continued to patrol the sky.

Gold/Richter arrived late. He stowed his Pokégear after concluding his conversation with Professor Elm; the data on Houndoom still lingered on the screen as he crossed the threshold. He paused for a moment upon spotting the three additional figures.

Mini Skirt Krise was the first to speak to him, in a soft voice:

“Good evening, Gold/Richter.”

Juggler Mike watched him for a moment before speaking, without any aggression:

“You seem disappointed to see us… or perhaps worried?”

Gold/Richter did not reply straight away. He glanced at the three trainers, then let out a quiet little sigh.

Bird Keeper Bryan, who had remained by the window, continued calmly:

‘If you’re worried about the crows… we arrived separately. They’re more restless than usual, but they’re still just birds. I’ve spent time observing them. Their behaviour isn’t all that different from that of other birds, once you know what to look for.’

Mini Skirt Krise lowered her gaze slightly before adding:

“We’ve come because Chris/Maria warned us. You’re the one fighting them right now. For us.”

Gold/Richter remained standing, the snow melting slowly on his shoulders. It took him a moment to reply, his voice low:

“Thank you for coming. But you don’t need to get involved. I’m fighting on behalf of those who can’t fight for themselves. Those who have neither the strength nor the will to do so.”

Juggler Mike crossed his arms, lost in thought.

“We would have liked to fight alongside you.”

Gold/Richter shook his head slowly.

“No. It is not for you to bear such a burden. I can afford to fight because I am… a little more capable than most. That is no reason for you to be dragged into it.”

Mini Skirt Krise looked up.

“So… a Pokédex holder taking on Team Rocket, just like three years ago?”

Gold/Richter gave a half-hearted smile.

“I’m not Red. And I’m not trying to be.”

Juggler Mike let out a quiet, almost affectionate chuckle.

“You do have a slightly aristocratic air about you at times, despite all your modesty.”

Gold/Richter raised an eyebrow slightly, without any real irritation.

“What are you on about?”

“Never mind,” replied Mike with a shrug. “I was merely teasing you.”

BGM “EP03 S02 16:50 17:30”

Bird Keeper Bryan stepped a little closer, his voice calm:

“If you think we trust you simply because you possess a Pokédex, you are mistaken. Red was not merely powerful. He fought for ordinary people, without looking down on them. You are doing much the same thing.”

“That is why we are here. Not to urge you to grow stronger, but to tell you that we, too, take our role seriously.” Mike continued.

Mini Skirt Krise nodded gently.

“In Johto, people remember Red not so much for his victories as for the way he fought for others.”

Gold/Richter remained silent for a long moment. He looked down at his hands, as if weighing his words.

“…Thank you,” he said at last. His voice was quieter. “But there’s one thing that’s not right. I don’t have a partner like his. I chose to keep him at a distance.”

Mini Skirt Krise looked at him with a gentle, almost sad expression.

“Does it really make any difference? You can easily play both Red and his partner.”

Chris/Maria, who had been watching without intervening until now, crossed her arms and let out a quiet chuckle. Her tone wavered between sarcasm and something warmer:

“Ha. He’ll bring us hope and courage in the snow, just like his Charizard.”

Gold/Richter turned his head towards her, slightly unbalanced. He was not immediately sure whether she was mocking him or not. Chris/Maria held his gaze for a moment, without adding anything, then looked away towards the snow falling outside the window.

Eusine, who had been standing back, let out a small, stifled chuckle. He approached slowly, his hands in his pockets.

“Charizard is no longer the most powerful Pokémon,” he said calmly. “But it’s the one that refuses to let the snow and darkness swallow everything up. The same goes for Red… and for you, Gold/Richter. You don’t have to feel inferior just because you don’t have the same strength as him.”

He paused, then added, looking him straight in the eye:

“By the way… this time, it is my turn to ask you for a private word.”

Gold/Richter looked at him, then glanced at the others. Eusine shook his head slightly.

“No. Not in front of everyone. It’s a bit too sentimental a question.”

End of scene

Scene – The Heroes’ Vulnerabilities

Street, in Goldenrod City

BGM: ‘Lacrimosa – Mozart’, arranged by Edouard de Nocturne EP06S01 14:20-16:37

Twilight had almost given way to night. The snow was falling thicker, muffling the sounds around them. They had turned into a side alley, far enough away to escape the Murkrow. The light from a lantern flickered faintly on the accumulated snow.

Gold/Richter kept his hands in his pockets for a moment, his eyes downcast. When he spoke, his voice was low and hesitant:

‘…Why did your sentimentality get the better of you this time?’

Eusine didn’t reply straight away. He watched the snow falling between them.

“It was just a convenient excuse,” he said at last. His voice was calm. “You deserved to be able to talk without being watched. Without everyone listening.”

Gold/Richter raised his head slightly.

“So… why did you mention Charizard just now, then?”

Eusine turned his head towards him. There was a quiet weariness in his gaze.

“And why do you always put yourself below Red? Even when you’re trying to be modest.”

Gold/Richter gave a half-hearted smile.

“Is it that obvious?”

“That is the most obvious part, yes.”

Gold/Richter looked down again. Eusine continued, more gently:

“…Are you afraid of becoming a hero?”

Gold/Richter clenched his hands slightly in his pockets. It took him a moment to reply.

“…I fight because not everyone is capable of it. I don’t want to be. And…”

He paused for a longer moment, then added in a hoarser voice:

“I’ve already messed everything up trying not to repeat his mistakes. I hurt Chris/Maria… and I’m afraid of losing even more.”

Eusine did not look away.

“Are you afraid of suffering the same fate as Red…?”

Gold/Richter nodded faintly:

“...I respect Red. But I’m afraid of ending up like him. Not because he was naive. But because I believe he wouldn’t have made that decision if he’d been able to foresee the consequences. I’m afraid of losing what’s left of my... happiness. The old way doesn’t work anymore. And I don’t know what to do instead.”

He lowered his head. A little snow had gathered on his hair and shoulders without him seeming to notice. His fingers, tucked inside his pockets, clenched and unclenched nervously. He drew in a breath through his nose, slowly, as if to hold back something that threatened to rise up.

Eusine stood a few paces away from him, arms crossed. He had not come any closer. Snow swirled gently between them. He studied Gold/Richter’s tense profile for a long moment before replying. When he spoke, his voice was calm, but grave.

‘…Red’s method is obsolete today. But it was innovative in its day. You don’t have to replicate it. You just have to find your own.’

Eusine remained silent for a moment. The snow continued to fall.

“There’s no shame in that,” he said at last. “Chris/Maria and I are worried too. Fighting isn’t our forte.”

Gold/Richter looked up at him.

“So… your decision to stay? Is it just because you’re attached to the region? That’s not very sensible…”

Eusine let out a small sigh, almost a weary laugh.

“I don’t think you have to be a hero to protect those who matter to you. That goes for me. And it goes for you too. You don’t have to carry that burden as a source of shame.”

He paused briefly, then continued in a lower voice.

“…And that’s why I asked you to come out here. There’s something I wanted to tell you without the others around. Something we tend to forget when we talk about Red.”

Gold/Richter looked at him without saying a word.

Eusine continued.

“It is often said that Charizard embodies hope and courage. That is true, to a certain extent. He has stood up to many Team Rocket grunts over the years. But against Giovanni, it was different. Giovanni had a strong command of the Ground-type. And Charizard, despite his power, remains extremely vulnerable to the Rock-type. A single well-thought-out strategy on Giovanni’s part could have put him in serious trouble.”

Eusine looked intently at Gold/Richter.

“Red must have had to battle under far more unfavourable conditions than is generally realised. Even his most iconic Pokémon didn’t have the upper hand. That means Red must have had to cope with far more pressure and risk than we can imagine.”

Gold/Richter remained silent. Eusine continued, more gently.

“That is why I do not blame you for leaving your original partner behind. You chose to protect yourself, and not to stake everything on a single Pokémon. That is not a weakness. You do not need to have a Charizard at your side to be legitimate, nor to protect those you hold dear.”

Gold/Richter kept his eyes downcast for a moment. When he looked up, his voice was more fragile:

“…Thank you. But… why all this kindness, exactly? Because I’m a hero in the making? Or simply because I might be of use to others?”

Eusine looked at him for a long time.

“…Because I refuse to reduce people like you to nothing more than your role as a hero. Red was treated like that for years. People forgot that he was also a human being, with his flaws, his loneliness, his doubts. I don’t want to repeat that. Not with you. Not with those of your generation.”

Gold/Richter was speechless for a moment.

Eusine remained silent for a moment, his gaze lost in the snow falling outside the window. When he spoke, his voice was low, almost weary.

“This goes beyond what I can offer you in place of your peers. I’ve seen the price you’ve paid for their absence.”

He slowly turned his head towards him. There was neither pity nor any grandiose promise in his gaze, only a kind of gentle candour.

“I will do everything in my power to ease the burden as much as I can. But I won’t deceive you: I won’t be able to fill that void. Not entirely.”

Gold/Richter did not reply straight away. He lowered his eyes slightly to his hands, clasped together on his lap. A very slight nod, almost imperceptible, was his only reaction.

Eusine added, more calmly.

“You’re still young. And you already have things that Red didn’t have at your age. Your sense of grounding. Your way of thinking. You don’t have to walk in his shadow. You can do things your own way.”

He paused one last time, then concluded softly:

“And if one day you lose your way… try to remember what you already have within you. It’s more precious than you might think.”

Gold/Richter remained silent for a long while. The snow was falling thicker now. When he spoke, his voice was lower, almost weary.

“Thank you for your words of comfort. But we live in a mad age where the fate of the world constantly depends on children my age… hardly conceivable. Or rather, absurd.”

Eusine looked at him with an expression that was both sad and gentle.

“I grant you that… It means that at your age one possesses something that is lost as soon as one becomes an adult, yet which is so precious to preserve… A mere conjecture.”

Gold/Richter did not reply. He kept his eyes fixed on the snow.

Eusine added, almost in a whisper.

‘You’re still hesitating, aren’t you?’

Gold/Richter nodded faintly.

“No. I simply know just how fragile humans are.”

BGM “Alone for Many Years”

At the end of the street, one of the Kimono Girls stood upright, very upright. She had just finished a brief dance. A Murkrow flew past her without noticing her. She turned her head slightly in their direction. Her gaze did not linger, but there was in that fleeting gesture a kind of discreet, almost silent kindness.

Eusine followed her movement with his eyes, then murmured.

“If the Murkrow are the messengers of the ancient world… then perhaps certain things, however fragile they may be, still carry a kind of light.”

The bell she wore tinkled softly in the snowy night.

End of scene

Scene – The Clinical Trial of the God of Death

Inside the Radio Tower

BGM ‘Your Choice’

Night enveloped the Radio Tower. Outside, the snow fell silently, muffling all sound. Inside, Chris/Maria and Gold/Richter made rapid progress along the emergency route. Their footsteps echoed too loudly in the deserted corridor.

Too quiet.

Gold/Richter warned in a low voice:

'…This isn't right. Not a single enemy.'

'They're waiting for us further up. Stay alert,' she replied.

They pressed on without slowing. Yet the higher they climbed, the more oppressive the silence became. No sound of footsteps. No distant shouts. No movement in the side corridors. Only the faint crackling of the neon lights and the soft whistling of the wind seeping through the cracks in the windows.

Gold/Richter felt his back exposed. Each step brought them closer to the staircase, but also to a place where they could see nothing. He had the unpleasant feeling that something **was following** them without making a sound. Not a Pokémon. Not a henchman. Just… a presence that was not there yet, but which already seemed to have spotted them.

Chris/Maria tightened her grip slightly on her Poké Ball. She said nothing, but her gaze swept the shadows with a sense of contained tension.

The corridor was empty. Too empty. And in that emptiness, the air seemed slightly colder than it ought to have been.

Then, without warning, a thick, black mist swept into the corridor from ahead. Visibility plummeted in an instant, as if the darkness itself had grown denser.

BGM 'Your Choice' – 01:09–

A flutter of wings, very brief, almost muffled by the fog.

The black fog engulfed the corridor with sudden ferocity. Within a matter of seconds, visibility had almost completely vanished. The walls, the floor, and even Chris/Maria, less than two metres away, became blurred shapes, as if viewed through ink.

Gold/Richter immediately sensed that something had changed. The air had grown colder, denser. And above all, he could no longer see clearly.

A faint but rapid flapping of wings echoed somewhere above him. Then nothing.

BGM 'Your Choice' – 01:19–

He gripped his hunting crop more tightly. He did not summon a Pokémon. In this near-total darkness, he could not risk exposing one of his partners to a surprise attack. He had to make do with what he had.

The hunting crop cracked through the air with a sharp snap, tracing a defensive arc in front of him and Chris/Maria. The leather whistled, but met nothing but empty space.

A moment later, the Murkrow darted out from his left, low and fast. Gold/Richter reacted instinctively and cracked the whip in that direction. The raven dodged with exasperating precision, changing course at the last moment as if it had anticipated the blow. It brushed past Gold/Richter without touching him, then vanished back into the fog.

Chris/Maria took a step back, her back almost pressed against the wall.

Silence returned, heavier than before. Gold/Richter could feel his heart beating faster. He could see almost nothing. He could only react to the sounds — the faint rustling of wings against the walls, the shift in the air as the Murkrow changed direction.

Then he realised.

It wasn't a wild Pokémon. The way it moved, the precision with which it dodged, the way it returned without seeking to hurt him straight away… it was all too controlled.

Gold/Richter uttered in a tense, low voice:

"It's Murkrow's Haze… Executive Athena is here."

He took a step back to move closer to Chris/Maria, the hunting crop still held taut before him.

"Watch out, above all, for what it's going to try in that fog. If we run… a single blow to the back and it's all over. Flank me, Chris/Maria."

The Murkrow reappeared, this time from the right. Gold/Richter spun round and cracked his hunting crop once more. The raven dodged again, with the same cold precision. It was not trying to hurt him. It was testing him. It was forcing Gold/Richter to keep turning round, to expose his back, to waste energy in the dark.

Gold/Richter felt sweat beading on his forehead. Every crack of the whip cost him a little more effort. He could see almost nothing. He could only react to sounds and the movement of the air. And every time he struck, the raven was already gone.

He gritted his teeth. He could not properly protect Chris/Maria under these circumstances. All he could do was try to cover the area in front of them, hoping the Murkrow would not get round behind them.

The fog remained thick. And somewhere in that darkness, the Murkrow continued to circle — patient, methodical, as if taking note of every second during which Gold/Richter had to guess rather than see.

Then, without warning, Gold/Richter struck once more.

It was not a gesture of caution, nor even of restrained anger. It was another strike, more forceful, more resounding. The leather cracked through the air with a sharp, amplified violence, as if all the tension built up in his arm had converged in that single movement. The hunting crop traced a wide, brutal arc, seeking to force its way through the space, to impose a presence where visibility had been stolen.

Yet from within the black mist, Murkrow rose.

The evasion was expert, precise, almost dismissive in its economy of movement.

BGM 'Your Choice' – ~01:42

The raven did not merely avoid the blow: it anticipated it, changing altitude with a precision that was as much a matter of instinct as of intellect. It soared above the whip's trajectory as if it had already calculated, several seconds earlier, the maximum height Gold/Richter could still reach in this state of fatigue and darkness — and as if it had decided that the risk of a direct hit was worth taking.

The leather met nothing but empty air.

For a split second, Gold/Richter felt a sharp, cold disappointment. He had counted on — without even realising it — the fact that Murkrow, being physically vulnerable, would hesitate to expose itself in this way. That variable had been swept aside. The silence that followed the crack was heavier than the fog itself. A few seconds during which all that could be heard was the faint rustling of wings somewhere above, and Gold/Richter's shallow breathing.
The Murkrow retreated once more into the fog without pressing the issue. It wasn't trying to force a confrontation. It was waiting. Watching. As if taking note of how Gold/Richter reacted when he could neither see nor anticipate correctly.

The fog remained thick. And somewhere in that darkness, the Murkrow continued to circle.

The black mist lifted in patches, but did not disappear completely. Wispy strands of Haze still hung in the air.

Gold/Richter and Chris/Maria advanced back-to-back. Their footsteps were heavy. The Murkrow did not charge them head-on. It reappeared from behind, brushed past Gold/Richter with a sharp flap of its wing, then vanished again. A few seconds later, it returned from another angle, still swift, still precise. It struck, retreated, observed.

Chris/Maria, for her part, remained still for the time being. She was studying the Murkrow's rhythm. Then, with a sharp, decisive movement, she reached for her belt and threw the Poké Ball.

Dewgong appeared in a cold gust of air.
Then, as if the notion had just occurred to it, Murkrow began emitting Haze once more. It hovered slightly askew, lazily yet with calculated precision, restoring the fog.
Without a word, Chris/Maria raised her hand and gave the command.

An icy wind swept through the corridor. **Icy Wind** struck with force. The fog tore apart in large patches. However, the black veil did not disappear entirely. Patches of it lingered, and the Murkrow, which had retreated to a safe distance, seemed unaffected. But the additional effect of Haze partially counteracted the reduction in speed. Only the biting cold reached the Murkrow and the two Trainers, causing no tangible damage.

Gold/Richter realised at once: even though the fog had partially cleared, it would not be enough. The Murkrow was already returning, flying lower, targeting his legs with surgical precision. The whip cracked violently and forced it to retreat. The raven flew off at once, without pressing the attack.

The Haze gradually reformed. Gold/Richter could feel his heart racing every time visibility dropped. The Murkrow reappeared once more. This time, it did not strike. It hovered for a moment in the gloom, its eyes fixed on Gold/Richter, as if assessing his state of tension. Then it retreated again, without pressing the attack.

Gold/Richter wiped the sweat trickling down his temple. He sensed that this was no battle. It was a **methodical battle of attrition**.

Athena appeared at the end of the corridor.

She walked with a calm, almost languid stride, her arms crossed. Her Arbok glided silently by her side. The Murkrow returned to perch on her shoulder with almost ceremonial precision.

Athena watched them for a moment, a faint smile playing on her lips:

'You are most gracious to remember me, young master.'

Murkrow cried out jubilantly in Lambda's voice:

"**Looong live Master Giovanni…!**"

BGM 'Your Choice' 02:38

Chris/Maria comprehended at once. She cried out, breathlessly:

"What are you waiting for? Don't stop!"

Gold/Richter dashed towards the stairs, his whip continuing to crack behind him.

With a tiny gesture, Athena gave the order.

The Murkrow abandoned Chris/Maria without a second glance. It charged straight at Gold/Richter and struck him in the back with a sharp, violent blow. **The Pursuit** continued.

The impact sent Gold/Richter stumbling forwards. He stifled a cry and had to put a hand on the floor to stop himself from falling.

Chris/Maria reacted immediately. Dewgong fired a barrage of icy shards. **Ice Shard**.

The Murkrow narrowly dodged the attack; one of the shards grazed its wing. It let out a brief cry, but did not pursue Chris/Maria. It straightened up and immediately turned its attention to Gold/Richter.

It charged once more, lower and more directly. Gold/Richter, still on his knees, spun round and cracked his whip with force… but struck only empty air. The Murkrow had already changed course at the last moment.

The raven hovered for a moment above him. It stared at him. Not with hatred. Not with mockery. Simply with the cold, satisfied focus of a creature that had achieved the result it expected.

Gold/Richter struggled to his feet. His breathing was short and laboured. The Murkrow took advantage of this. It would return, strike, then fly off again. Always the same precise, almost methodical rhythm.

Chris/Maria quickly realised what the Murkrow was doing. It was not trying to defeat them here; it was trying to **wear** Gold/Richter **down**.

The Murkrow launched another charge, lower and more direct. Gold/Richter raised his whip to parry, but the raven changed course at the last moment and struck him in the back. Gold/Richter stifled a cry and stumbled forwards.

The Murkrow did not pursue him. It rose again, hovered, and stared at him for a moment. Then, without pressing the attack, it turned on its heel and calmly returned to Athena's shoulder.

Chris/Maria asked breathlessly:

'Why such nonchalance?'

Athena smiled coldly: "He would have considered himself lucky to keep me company… Well, our director is more formidable than you can imagine. It was rather bold of him to face the guardian of hell rather than the god of death. My sympathy…"

BGM 'Your Choice' 03:26

The Murkrow perched on Athena's shoulder. It turned its head slightly one last time towards the staircase down which Gold/Richter had disappeared. Its eyes remained fixed on that spot for a moment, as if taking in the final outcome.

The Haze began to thicken around Athena once more.

Scene – Radio Tower (stealth passage)

BGM: 'Your Choice', the rest

The light was dim in this side corridor of the Radio Tower. Lance stood in the shadows, arms crossed, his gaze fixed on a small monitor recessed into the wall. The image was grainy, but clear enough. He was watching Gold and the young girl who had just passed through the passageway a few moments earlier.

He did not move. He had not moved for several minutes.

"They've gone through," he said in a low voice. "Just as expected."

Silence. He brushed the screen with his fingertips, without really looking at it.

"Athena must be receiving them now. I left the passage clear for them… so that she could wear them down first."

He paused, his eyes half-closed.

"The boy… He's putting up more of a fight than expected. Athena shouldn't be overwhelmed by that young lady. But him… he might give her a bit of trouble."

His voice remained calm, almost detached. Yet something darker crept into his tone as he added:

'Shall I deal with him personally?'

He let the question hang, then dismissed it with a slight shake of his head.

"No. Revenge is a vulgar thing. It clouds judgement and impairs precision. Athena can still handle it. If I intervene too soon, I risk depriving Apollo of part of the spectacle he is looking forward to. And that would be… regrettable."

He sat up slightly.

"What's more… I have no intention of repeating the mistake made by a certain eccentric."

A very faint, almost imperceptible smile flitted across her lips before vanishing.

"A few days ago, at Team Rocket HQ, a certain champion interfered in a battle on a mere whim. Athena hasn't quite shaken off her lingering resentment; she must confront that vulgar feeling today. As for me, I have no intention of becoming that sort of spectacular disruption. Not now."

He turned his head slightly towards the corridor, as if assessing the moment.

"I could frighten them by appearing. Unnerve them. But that would be too lenient. Apollo deserves to see just how far this young intruder can go when he's led to believe he still has a chance. I can't wait to see how he plays this hand. Really."

He took a step out of the shadows.

“The temperature, the light, the humidity… everything’s just right. Now’s the time.”

A calm, almost melancholic voice rang out behind him.

“It’s all unfolding… just as in the prospect. Isn’t it?”

Lance froze. Very slowly, he turned his head.

Eusine was there, sitting on an old ventilation duct, his legs crossed, as if he had been waiting for a while. His gaze was steady, yet tinged with an age-old weariness.

Lance stared at him in silence for a moment, before replying in a cold, measured voice:

“How long have you been there?”

Eusine didn’t reply straight away. He looked down at his own hands.

“You’re not that strong, Lance. Not really. But you’re patient. And you know exactly when to interfere. That’s more dangerous than brute force.”

He slowly looked up.

“You let those two through on purpose. So that Athena would wear them down first. And now you’re preparing to step in at the most opportune moment. Not too soon. Not too late. Like a craftsman who waits until the piece is almost finished before adding his finishing touch.”

Lance said nothing. His expression remained impassive, but his eyes had narrowed slightly.

Eusine continued, in a lower voice:

‘The true creatures of the night aren’t your Pokémon, Lance. They’re Trainers like you. Those who have learnt to turn cruelty into a mere matter of timing.’

A Poké Ball had already appeared between his fingers. Yet he did not throw it. He simply held it there, as if he were still hesitating to give form to the human horror he had just named.

Lance regarded him for a long moment.

Then, in a low, almost courteous voice, Lance replied:

“You talk too much.”

End of scene

Scene – A job interview

Top of the Radio Tower

The snow fell silently. Outside, the world seemed to have frozen beneath a pristine white blanket. Only the moon, cold and distant, cast a pale light over the landscape. Inside, the large room was

plunged into darkness. The monitoring equipment gave off a faint bluish glow, but no one was looking at it. The radio broadcast had been cut off long ago. The transmitter lay on the console, abandoned, like an object that had served its purpose.

Apollo stood by the large bay window, his hands clasped behind his back. He watched the Murkrow gliding silently through the snowy night. They weren't calling out. They weren't hunting. They were simply circling, as if waiting without haste. Apollo seemed neither tense nor in a hurry. He was content just to be there, like a man with all the time in the world.

He sensed the approach even before the footsteps became distinct. A presence climbing the stairs cautiously. He did not turn round immediately. He let the visitor cross the threshold, walk partway across the room, and stop a few metres away from him.

Only then did he turn round, with measured slowness.

BGM: 'Work of the Devil'

'So, you've made it this far after all?'

Gold/Richter stood in the shadows, his face half-lit by the moon. He did not reply straight away. He could feel the weight of the situation bearing down on him far more heavily than his physical exhaustion. He knew he was not in a position to face several executives at once. Lance was still in the vicinity, even though he was currently being held up by Eusine. Athena was not far away either. And standing before him was Apollo.

He was neither Green nor Red. He knew that. His approach did not allow him to compensate with brute force or unwavering dominance. That realisation weighed heavier than any injury.

'Our paths have crossed after all. Isn't that right, Apollo?'

Apollo tilted his head slightly. A faint, almost imperceptible smile touched his lips.

"Does my reputation precede me? I assume it was Lance who mentioned my existence to you?"

Gold/Richter did not reply. He tried to keep a neutral expression, but Apollo saw very clearly the flash of surprise cross his eyes. An almost childlike surprise at such a precise and clinical reading.

Apollo tilted his head further, looking amused.

"That hesitation alone is enough to confirm my conjecture."

He took a step to the side, still showing no sign of aggression, and continued in a calm voice:

"First Lance, then Athena, alerted me to a young man who had meddled in our affairs. I didn't expect it to be the same person."

He paused, clearly savouring the irony.

"Athena didn't give me much information about you… Presumably because she was focusing on the champion's intervention rather than on you. Apparently, without that, she would have settled the matter without much difficulty."

Gold/Richter clenched his jaw slightly. It was not the blow to his ego that weighed heaviest; it was the implicit confirmation of what he had already feared: he was not seen as a major threat. And in a situation where he might find himself facing several executives, that put him in an even more precarious position.

“So, am I not worthy of your attention simply because I’m a child?”

Apollo regarded him for a moment, his eyes gleaming with a look that was both amused and dangerous.

“That is his potential opinion, not mine. And amongst my subordinates, Lance is the only one impertinent enough to offer such an obscene favour and exploit my identity.”

He turned slightly towards the window, whilst continuing to speak.

“Tell me, young man. Are you here to apply for the job?”

“What? Are you joking?”

Apollo smiled openly this time, but without any warmth.

“We, the four executives, each excel in a major field: Lambda in popular obscenity, Lance in cruel craftsmanship, Athena in insidious tactics. This uniqueness sometimes attracts young people who aspire to join us.”

He made a vague gesture with his hand.

“Three years ago, another teenager was eager to keep us company on several occasions. You’re here either to join us or out of some personal obsession, aren’t you?”

“Spare me your whims, I beg you.”

Apollo stared at him intently for a long moment. His expression shifted subtly, becoming colder, more precise.

“The real whim is to be obsessed with us at your age, like the red-haired boy. As for him, it’s retaliation. But as for you… what is your motive? Is it more… sublime?”

He took a step towards him, without any direct threat, but with a presence that seemed to fill the entire space.

“Or… could it be that you, too, are a Pokédex holder? Like the one who once dismantled Team Rocket?”

Gold/Richter did not reply, though he made no secret of his surprise at having been exposed, despite his precautions. Apollo nodded slowly, as if this confirmed something he had already suspected:

“How providential. The same story seems to be repeating itself. Or rather… the same imprecation, I presume?”

“I’ve had enough of superstition. Now, in what field do you excel? And wouldn’t you like to suspend this hateful broadcast…?”

BGM « EP01 S02 22 :51-23 :40 »

Apollo regarded him for a long time. His green eyes caught the faint moonlight. When he replied, his voice was lower, almost gentle:

“Your question will meet its answer… provided you invite me to battle.”

Silence fell once more.

Apollo stood motionless. He simply watched Gold/Richter, neither pressing him nor openly threatening him. He was simply leaving the choice up to him. As if the outcome of this encounter lay entirely in the other man's hands.

BGM « EP01 S02 22 :51-23 :40 » 00 :38-

Gold/Richter felt the weight of that responsibility. He knew he was not in a position to control everything. He knew that one wrong move could make the situation unmanageable. And Apollo, with his clinical calm, was holding him to account without another word.

Outside, the snow continued to fall. The Murkrow were still circling silently in the night.

The scene may end on this silence, before fading to **BGM 'EP01 S02 22 :51-23 :40.**
End of scene

Close of episode

Totals

≈ 11,400 words · 27 pp. A4 · read aloud ≈ 75 min.

Pass 1/3 — still open

niveleur (not Leveller). Pursuit ≠ the chase. Silver: him, not her. Murkrow generation: its, not their. Looong live Master Giovanni! Poké Balls ≠ bullets. hunting crop ≠ whip. imprecation ≠ curse. Authorial voice at the summit to cut. Doublon of the step back. P1 bis on the cut block (Weight of Promises → bell).

Version notes

2026-09-23 — EN-GB apparatus after P1. GSC TM, Lambda levels, Pursuit 80, two Lances. Traces = address. Bell Tower. Author filled. Title: White and Snowy Hell. Athena single EN spelling.

Open for what follows

Battle with Apollo · Eusine / Lance · Houndoom still unseen.

BGM credits

Pieces: Castlevania: Nocturne (Netflix), Trevor Morris & Trey Toy. Traces: duration only.